

As the number of singles grows in cities, support groups spring up to give them a space of their own

By Nishat Bari |

Ever since she lost her husband nine years ago, Manjushree Sathe was resigned to a life of loneliness till she chanced upon an advertisement for a support group of elderly people in Pune called Anand Yatra. A first tentative call to the group turned Sathe's world around. She now has a group of 12 friends with whom she regularly watches movies and plays. Her fondest memory of the group revolves around a trip they had made to Lonavala. She broke her arm while on

the trip and was extremely touched by the way the group members went out of their way to help her. "Nobody ate lunch till 4 p.m. because they were trying to find an orthopaedic surgeon to fix my arm." Before joining Anand Yatra, Sathe didn't have friends or relatives in the city to spend time with. A retired teacher of 59, she has now found a support system in her neighbourhood.

Loneliness is no longer a disease that plagues only the young and single living in large cities. The reasons vary from separations to single professionals from smaller towns living without their families to people who have been widowed to not having found the right person. Now, there are new options available of building a social network, which needn't be romantic in nature. All one needs to do



Single TOGETHER



is go online and check for singles' clubs in one's city, but not without being wary of the fly-by-night singles' clubs, which are a cover for sexual activities. With an increasing number of legitimate clubs, however, people can find companions without getting into a sexual or romantic relationship. Clubs like Footloose-Fancy Free No More in Mumbai and Anand Yatra are becoming increasingly popular across different age groups.

Hemant Devasthali, principal of Pune's Ness Wadia College of Commerce, formed Anand Yatra after he lost his wife in an accident. He felt

HEMANT DEVASTHALI
FOUNDER OF ANAND YATRA

"We started out with five members and now there are so many people. It makes me very happy to see the change this group has brought in the lives of its members."



terribly lonely and himself and others are people over time find companions partners. Mandak came to Anand soulmate. She mo lecture organised within two months died. "We were knew we could sh. Footloose is a